

Creamy Caramelized Cauliflower Pasta

This creamy cauliflower pasta is the ultimate comfort food—rich, velvety and flavorful. With simple ingredients and quick prep, it's a satisfying dish that feels fancy without the fuss and is the ideal meal for a cozy weeknight dinner. Add a squeeze of lemon or a pinch of chile flakes to elevate this easy, comforting classic even more!

By **Melissa Gray-Streett** | Updated on August 22, 2025

 Reviewed by Dietitian **Emily Lachtrupp, M.S., RD**

Active Time: 35 mins

Total Time: 40 mins

Servings: 4

Nutrition Profile:

No Added Sugar Gut Healthy Mediterranean Diet Sesame-Free Weight Loss Nut-Free Soy-Free High-Fiber Vegetarian High-Protein Egg-Free

Ingredients

- 8 ounces whole-wheat rotini (about 2¾ cups)
- 3 tablespoons unsalted butter, divided
- 1 small head cauliflower (1 pound), cut into 1-inch florets (4 cups)
- ¾ teaspoon salt
- ¼ cup thinly sliced garlic (from 8 large garlic cloves)
- 2 tablespoons water
- 2 teaspoons fresh thyme leaves, plus more for garnish
- ¾ teaspoon ground pepper, plus more for garnish
- 2 tablespoons sherry vinegar
- ½ cup sour cream
- ¼ cup heavy cream
- ½ cup grated Parmesan cheese, divided

Directions

Step 1

Bring a large saucepan of water to a boil. Cook 8 ounces rotini according to package directions for al dente. Reserve ½ cup cooking water; drain the pasta.

Step 2

Meanwhile, melt 2 tablespoons butter in a large nonstick skillet over medium heat. Add cauliflower florets and $\frac{3}{4}$ teaspoon salt in an even layer. Cook, undisturbed, until browned on the bottom, 5 to 7 minutes. Stir; cook, stirring occasionally, until golden brown all over, 5 to 8 minutes. Add $\frac{1}{4}$ cup garlic; cook, stirring occasionally, until fragrant, about 1 minute. Add 2 tablespoons water, 2 teaspoons thyme, $\frac{3}{4}$ teaspoon pepper and the remaining 1 tablespoon butter; cook, stirring occasionally, until the cauliflower is well coated, about 2 minutes. Stir in 2 tablespoons vinegar; cook, stirring often, until the liquid has mostly evaporated, about 30 seconds. Remove from heat.

Step 3

When the pasta is done, return the cauliflower mixture to medium heat; stir in the cooked pasta, the reserved $\frac{1}{2}$ cup cooking water, $\frac{1}{2}$ cup sour cream, $\frac{1}{4}$ cup heavy cream and $\frac{1}{4}$ cup Parmesan. Cook, stirring constantly, until the sauce becomes creamy and coats the pasta, 1 to 2 minutes. Divide among 4 bowls. Top with the remaining $\frac{1}{4}$ cup Parmesan. Garnish with additional thyme leaves and pepper, if desired.

Frequently Asked Questions

How do I choose the best head of cauliflower?

If you're buying a whole head of cauliflower, lift it first. It should feel heavy for its size, with firm, tight florets and no dark spots or yellow leaves.

Can I substitute the pasta shape?

We recommend using rotini, but feel free to choose any pasta shape you prefer. Opt for shapes that hold sauce well, such as shells, campanelle or penne.

What should I serve with cauliflower creamy pasta?

Salad! Here are some of our favorite salads that would go perfectly with this dish: Best Caesar Salad with Crispy Parmesan, Simple Spinach Salad and Herb & Arugula Salad with Balsamic Vinaigrette. Pairing this creamy pasta with fresh rolls or bread to capture leftover sauce is a must.

How should I store and reheat leftovers?

Store leftovers in an airtight container for a maximum of 3 days in the refrigerator. Reheat in the microwave or on the stovetop, adding water to loosen the cheese sauce.

Nutrition Facts

Per serving: **Serving Size about 1¾ cups** 529 calories; total fat 25g; saturated fat 14g; cholesterol 69mg; sodium 702mg; total carbohydrate 62g; dietary fiber 9g; total sugars 4g; added sugars 0g; protein 18g; vitamin c 54mg; calcium 217mg; iron 3mg; potassium 621mg

Additional reporting by Carrie Myers, M.S. and Linda Frahm

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